Thorben Wölk

DATA & AI ENGINEER

CONTACT

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WEB
http://twoelk.codeandheart.com/

CITY
Hamburg, Germany

EDUCATION

Rheinische Friedrich-Wilhelms-Universität Bonn 2014 – 2017
Master of Science in Economics
Focus on Behavioral Economics. Thesis on "Diffusion of Responsibility".

Christian-Albrechts-Universität zu Kiel 2010 – 2013
Bachelor of Science in Business Administration

Fernuniversität in Hagen 2012 - 2019
Bachelor of Arts in Psychology

Université Paris I Panthéon-Sorbonne 2013 - 2014
Erasmus Exchange in Economics

SKILLS

PROGRAMMING LANGUAGES
Python, SQL, JavaScript/TypeScript, Rust

CLOUD PLATFORMS
Google Cloud Platform (GCP), Amazon Web Services (AWS), Microsoft Azure

DATA TECHNOLOGIES
Apache Spark, PySpark, Google Dataflow, Databricks, BigQuery, Redshift, dbt core, dbt platform/cloud, Azure Data Factory, PostgreSQL, SurrealDB, Pub/Sub, Kafka, Looker, Streamlit, Neo4j Cypher

MACHINE LEARNING AND AI
AWS Sagemaker, Vertex AI, sklearn, pytorch, pydantic-ai, ADK, langgraph, crew-ai, haystack, ollama, Claude Code, Cursor, Codex, Open Web UI

DEVOPS, CI/CD
Kubernetes, Docker, GitHub Actions, Terraform, ansible, cdk, CloudFormation, Grafana

METHODS
Agile Coaching, User Story Mapping, Test Driven Development (TDD)

LANGUAGES

German (Native), English (Fluent), Spanish (Basic), French (Basic)

SUMMARY

Combining engineering expertise with an agile mindset to develop data-driven solutions. Focusing on data pipelines, platform architecture, agentic AI applications, and DataOps.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCES

Self-Employed - Freelance Data & AI Engineer Sep 2025 – Present
- Completed recent certifications in Data Engineering and AI
- Secured government funding for freelance kickstart

ZEIT ONLINE - Head of Data Platform May 2023 – Aug 2025
- Leading data platform strategy and development for a major online news publisher
- Managing a team of 5+ data engineers, analytics engineers, and tracking experts
- Implementing user story mapping, a Kanban process, and release management

ZEIT ONLINE - Software Engineer Big Data Oct 2021 – Apr 2023
- **Data Platform**: Designed and built an end-to-end analytics platform with components of data ingestion, data transformation, reporting & data science, reverse ETL, and DataOps. Featuring multi-tenancy and a cloud-native scalable architecture. Built on Google Cloud, dbt platform, Kubernetes, Looker. Partly migrated from Microsoft Azure.
- **ELT/ETL**: Developed data ingestion applications for batch and streaming data. Event-based & pipeline architectures.
- **Data Science**: Developed data-driven applications for custom, advanced data analysis and AI.
- **DevOps**: Implemented IaC using Terraform, branching concepts, and CI/CD

EOS Group - Software Engineer Jan 2019 – Sep 2021
- **Data Platform**: Databricks data intelligence platform setup for debt collection analytics
- **MLOps Platform**: Full redesign of a machine learning platform as a cloud-native microservice architecture on AWS.
- **DevOps**: Automated infrastructure deployment using ansible, cdk, CloudFormation, and Jenkins

Forward3D - Junior PPC Analyst Sep 2017 – Nov 2018
- Analyzed and optimized pay-per-click campaigns for retail clients
- Automated daily and weekly reportings with Python and SQL

briq - Institute on Behavior and Inequality - Research Assistant Apr 2016 – May 2017
- Conducted data analysis with Python and R for economic research
- Contributed to publications on neuroeconomics and moral reasoning

CERTIFICATIONS

Databricks Data Engineer Associate — Databricks Feb 2026
Certified Data Engineer Associate

Neural Networks and Deep Learning — DeepLearning.AI Dec 2025

Agentic AI — DeepLearning.AI Dec 2025

Agile Coach — Beratung Judith Andresen July 2021

AWS Certified Solutions Architect – Associate 2020

PUBLICATIONS

"Spreading inequality: neural computations underlying paying-it-forward reciprocity" 2018
Social Cognitive and Affective Neuroscience